failing to gain international support for Tibet's independence.[35] Negotiations culminated in the May 1951 agreement in which China recognised "the existing political system in Tibet," left unaltered "the established status, functions and powers of the Dalai Lama," guaranteed "freedom of religious belief," and undertook the initiation of socioeconomic reforms gradually and in consultation with the people, while at the same time assuming responsibility for Tibet's economic and cultural relations with neighbouring countries and reorganising Tibetan troops and absorbing them into the PLA.[36]

That, in turn, set the stage for India and China to address the outstanding issues in their relationship pertaining to Tibet, namely the boundary question and India's inherited privileges. In the discussions and correspondence that ensued, Zhou maintained a studied silence on the boundary even when Nehru highlighted Zhou's statement to the Indian Ambassador in September 1951 that "there is no territorial dispute or controversy between India and China."[37] China's approach, as Sarvepalli Gopal later noted, was marked by a willingness to discuss only specific issues that were "ripe for settlement."[38] Although Nehru preferred "a general and comprehensive settlement" that included the frontier, he became convinced by K. M. Panikkar's argument that Zhou's "silence on the subject of the Frontier … would mean acquiescence in, if not acceptance of, India's position" and that, therefore, India must stick to the position that "the Frontier had been defined and there was nothing to be discussed."[39] Consequently, Nehru neither paid heed to the advice tendered by Secretary General G. S. Bajpai and Foreign Secretary K. P. S. Menon to establish a formal linkage between China's recognition of the boundary and India's withdrawal of its garrisons in Tibet nor approved the suggestion of T. N. Kaul to include "a definite declaration about the boundary" in India's general statement.[40] Instead,